ABOUT THIS PIECE

Case study: a student with ADHD

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WHAT IT IS

A case study analysis (Chapter 10) of an elementary student with ADHD: academic needs, strengths, and the supports an IEP can put in place.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

How each accommodation connects to a specific need.

Case study analysis: Student with ADHD

Chapter 10: Attention Deficit/Hyperactivity Disorder · Katherine Conklin

Student: Name **Grade:** Elementary **Classification:** ADHD **Plan:** Individualized Education Program (IEP)

A student diagnosed with ADHD, combined type, qualifies for services under an Individualized Education Program (IEP). The student shows symptoms of inattention, impulsivity, and hyperactivity, which significantly impact academic performance and classroom behavior. The IEP identifies specific academic, behavioral, and executive functioning challenges, and outlines a combination of accommodations and specialized instruction designed to help the student succeed in the least restrictive environment.

Academic needs of the student

Strengths

- Strong verbal reasoning and problem solving skills in hands-on learning activities
- Capable of mastering grade-level content with proper scaffolding and pacing

Challenges

- Frequently off task due to distractibility and poor attention
- Fails to complete assignments independently without frequent redirection
- Has difficulty with multi-step directions and organizing work

Behavioral needs of the student

- Impulsive behaviors (interrupting, leaving seat)
- Struggles with self-regulation during transitions and unstructured time
- Poor time management
- Frequently requires prompting to begin and maintain engagement

Top priorities

- **Executive functioning support:** improve memory, task initiation, and organization
- **Self-regulation and behavior management:** reduce impulsivity and increase self-monitoring
- **Academic engagement:** task completion, focus during instruction, and work output

These priorities align with the student's IEP and address the core deficits interfering with learning.

Specific objectives for the student

Executive functioning goal

By the end of the IEP term the student will use a visual checklist and timer to complete classroom assignments with no more than one adult prompt in 4 out of 5 trials, as measured by teacher observation and work completion logs.

Self-regulation goal

By the end of the IEP term, the student will use a designated self-monitoring tool (like a behavior chart or break card) to manage behavior during transitions and instruction.

Academic performance goal

By the end of the IEP term, the student will complete assigned classwork in reading and math with 80% accuracy, with support and accommodations in place.

Evidence-based practices to support differentiation

Instructional strategies

- **Chunking assignments:** break tasks into smaller steps with check-ins between each part
- **Visual schedules and timers:** provide structure and predictability
- **Graphic organizers and sentence starters:** help organize written responses

Behavioral supports

- **Positive reinforcement system:** a point system to reward on-task behavior
- **Brain breaks:** scheduled intervals allow physical activity to reduce restlessness
- **Self-monitoring tools:** daily goal charts, reflection logs, or apps for behavior tracking

Environmental modifications

- **Preferential seating:** near the teacher and away from distractions
- **Low-stimulation work area:** a quiet, reduced-distraction space for tests and independent work
- **Visual reminders and cues:** post class expectations and routines in multiple formats (written, icons, color-coded)

Collaboration and support services

- **Counselor/social worker check-ins:** weekly meetings for emotional regulation and goal review
- **Family communication plan:** home-school behavior tracker and weekly email updates
- **Special education staff support:** inclusion or resource room services for skill building

Final recommendations

- Regular communication between the school team and family for consistency across environments
- Use data tracking tools and weekly progress monitoring to determine effectiveness and make adjustments as needed
- General education teachers receive training on ADHD-friendly strategies and classroom support

This student with ADHD has strong potential to succeed in a general education setting with targeted support for executive functioning, behavior, and academic engagement. Through a combination of

structured routines, evidence-based instructional practices, and collaborative support, the student's learning experience can be enhanced significantly. The goal is to create a responsive, inclusive environment that promotes academic growth, emotional regulation, and independent functioning, empowering the student to thrive both in and out of the classroom.